# STATE SCAN

**BENGAL: THE BANERJEES IN A BALANCE** *PG 20*

**PUNJAB: BATTLE OF THE TAKHTS** *PG 22*



**THE CHALLENGER** Gaurav Gogoi during the panchayat poll campaign; (right) CM Himanta Sarma

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▶ ASSAM

# THE GOGOI GAMBIT

**The Congress is going all in with MP and legacy heir Gaurav Gogoi in the battle for Assam against Himanta Sarma's BJP in 2026**

*By* **Kaushik Deka**

**IT MAY HAVE BEEN A CORONATION WAITING TO HAPPEN,** but when it came—on May 26, with a year to go for the 2026 Assam assembly election—it rang out like a call to a duel from the days of feudal chivalry. Gaurav Gogoi, like a prince who had the throne snatched from him, has got his chance for avengement. Elevated as state Congress president by the high command, his formal investiture sets the stage for a most intense political slugfest, for Gogoi will be in the ring against a very combative incumbent CM, Himanta Biswa Sarma of the BJP, the mutineer who felled his father.

It's a classic setpiece, meant to end a frustrating decade of eclipse for the Congress, marked by utter BJP dominance over a state it had made a fresh conquest of only in 2016. Part of it rests on legacy. The late Tarun Gogoi's 15-year stint as CM is often associated with Assam's fitful passage out of its old militancy-hit phase into a measure of stability and prosperity.

But the package also offers a 'new, improved' version of his son, Gaurav, reimaged as the Grand Old Party's "face of revival", "a charismatic challenger". What aids this is the rise in Gaurav's own stature since his decisive win in the 2024